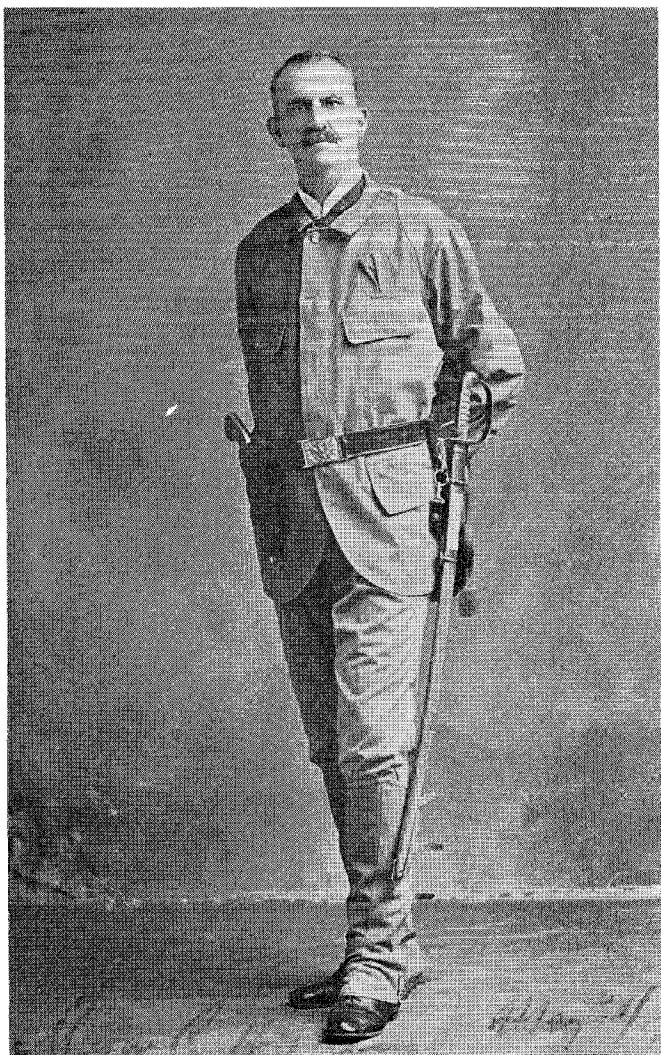




COLONEL RICHARD HENRY SAVAGE.

RICHARD HENRY SAVAGE.

No. 2224. CLASS OF 1868.

Died, October 11, 1903, New York City, aged 57.

RICHARD HENRY SAVAGE, the son of Richard and Jane Ewart Savage, was born in Utica, New York, June 12, 1846, where his family had lived for many years.

Savage came from pure English stock with a strain of Norman-French on his father's side, and from pure Highland Scotch on the maternal side. His father was a prominent manufacturer of Central New York, but with the discovery of gold in California, he closed out his business enterprises and joined that throng of eager Argonauts whose goal was the Golden Gate and the Aladdin land of California.

The elder Savage arrived in California in January, 1850, and soon had decided to make that fair land of promise his permanent home; in 1851 his family joined him, at this time young Savage was a lad of but five years of age, so that at an impressionable and plastic age, he came under the subtle and wonderful influences of the early years of California life, so full of the romance of marvellous achievement and the tragedy of common failure. It was a community of men, women were very scarce, and children so rare in those days of over fifty years ago, that it is recalled how Savage used to relate to his wondering classmates of the Atlantic Coast and Middle West, how he and his brother Jack would be stopped on their way to school by bearded, big-hearted miners and loaded with presents, the virgin nugget or bit of gold dust would be dropped into the small hand, and the big miner with a grip of homesickness at his heart would pass on.

His early education was acquired at the public schools of San Francisco, and he had completed the high school course before he was sixteen, and two years before receiving his appointment to the Military Academy.

While at the high school his literary ability was evident as his bent indicated by the preparation and publication jointly with his younger brother of quite a pretentious paper for those times, called the "San Francisco Eagle."

It may indeed, be said that young Savage "lisped in numbers" for he was barely thirteen when he was writing poetry and skits for the "San Francisco Bulletin."

It is an interesting coincidence that his first juvenile literary efforts were in collaboration with the De Young boys who had started a small paper called the San Francisco Dramatic Chronicle, and that many years after, in the same paper owned and edited by the last of the De Young Brothers, but enlarged and developed into the San Francisco Chronicle, Savage wrote for the Sunday edition of that paper his first successful short story "Billy Hitchens."

Upon leaving the high school Savage commenced the study of law in the offices of U. S. Senator James McDougal, and later he studied in the law offices of Halleck, Peachy & Billings, the senior member of which firm was then in the east or the "States" as Major General in the Union Armies.

The secession of the southern states in "61" found California nearly evenly divided in sentiment between the north and south, during the winter of "60-61" strong efforts were being made to take California out of the Union and ally her with the south.

To counteract this movement the Union men were well organized, and one of the most active and zealous workers was Richard Savage, Sr. The arrival, unexpected, save to the leaders of the Union party, of Col. E. V. Sumner, who had been sent out secretly by the Government at Washington, and who traveled incog under an assumed name, to relieve Col. Albert Sidney Johnson of the military command on the Pacific Coast, effectually scotched the secession movement in California.

When the Pony Express brought the news of the attack on Fort Sumpter and President Lincoln's first call for troops, enlistments quickly began for the "California Legion" for service in Virginia, young Savage, although barely fifteen, caught the fire of patriotic fervor and ran away from home and managed to enlist. After a search his father found him and procured his discharge on account of his extreme youth.

Richard Savage was the first federal official appointed by President Lincoln in the State of California, holding the important office of Collector of Internal Revenue from 1861 to 1873.

In 1864, through his father's influence, young Savage was appointed to the Military Academy from the San Jose district, and made the long journey by the Isthmian route at a time when the Pacific Mail liners, laden with heavy consignments of gold, were in danger of capture by the privateers of the Southern Confederacy.

The long voyage delayed his arrival at the "Point" in time to enter with the "Plebes" or June contingent of his class, but on September 1st Richard Henry Savage arrived and was among the first batch of "Seps" to report.

He was at this time a youth of most striking appearance, very tall and very thin, solemn of countenance, a sharp angular face, piercing black eyes, aquiline nose and heavy overhanging eye brows; his courteous address and readiness of speech quickly caught and held the attention.

His natural characteristics soon won him a prominent place both in his own class and with upper classmen.

It is no disparagement to others to say that he was the most brilliant Cadet at the Academy from 1864 to 1868.

He quickly became famous for a sparkling wit and repartee that gave pleasure and left no sting. Eloquent and witty in speech, big-hearted and loyal in his attachments, full of lofty ideals, courteous to the verge of Quixotic chivalry, Savage early

displayed those rare traits of mind and of disposition that through life won for him distinction from the many, and a deep affection from his intimates.

Gifted with a clear, logical and analytical mind, joined to a rich and glowing imagination, and the faculty of clothing his thoughts in concise and appropriate language, and with a most tenacious and marvellous memory, Savage was equally at home in the intricacies of the higher Mathematics as in studies like Law and Ethics. For the first two years Savage does not seem to have been especially ambitious for class standing, although he never stood below twenty in general standing, but circumstances arose in the last few months preceding "furlough" that determined him to graduate as high as possible, and accordingly the last two years of his Cadet life were marked by strenuous and unflagging work. His ambition was greater than his strength and for a short time he broke down from overwork, a short period of rest and he was again working with the old indomitable persistency. Although handicapped with having only fairly average marks and standing for the first two years, at final graduation he stood sixth in a class of fifty-five, and was within the "fives" in three studies out of six of the last year. He was graduated June 15, 1868, and commissioned Brevet Second Lieutenant, Corps of Engineers, and assigned to duty with Co. "D" Engineer Battalion, then stationed at the Engineer depot, Yerba Buena Island, San Francisco harbor. During the succeeding two years he was engaged in Engineer work in California and Arizona, having charge of important surveys of the Round Valley Indian reservation in northern California, the Presidio reservation, San Francisco, and the Pima and Maricopa reservation in Arizona. Although loving his profession and an ideal soldier both in the acquirement of knowledge and in the performance of his duties, he felt cramped in his narrow field, and ambition urged him to leave the service and essay his strength in the sharper struggles of civil life. Accordingly he tendered

his resignation and left the service December 31, 1870. He determined to see Europe before settling down to a business career, and through the kindness of President Grant he held Consular positions in Rome, Italy and Marseilles, France.

Travel and a short period of service in the General Staff of the Egyptian Army as Military Secretary to Major General Charles P. Stone, Chief of Staff, then followed, and in the summer of 1872 Savage came home and was appointed by President Grant one of three Commissioners to investigate and report upon border outrages along the Rio Grande. The duties of this commission were laborious and very important as the Mexican border troubles were becoming a burning question in the United States, and there were not a few willing and eager to precipitate trouble with the younger republic, hoping to reap a harvest therefrom. After two years of hard service on the border the commission made its final report in 1874, and Savage returned to San Francisco to become an iron founder in partnership with his father and brother, John Ewart Savage.

While in Texas his restless active mind found time to undertake the work of Chief Engineer of the Corpus Christi & Rio Grande Railway, a company that was later merged in the International R. R. Co.

In December, 1872, he was married to Madam Anna Josephine Scheible, of Berlin, Germany, the wedding took place at the German Embassy in Washington. Impetuous and romantic, this purely love match proved the greatest good of his life, for his marriage gave to Savage a faithful and devoted wife, a prudent and wise counsellor and a brilliant and cultivated companion that for thirty years brightened his life. Madam Savage was absent in Germany at the time of Col. Savage's death.

Savage remained in San Francisco actively engaged in large business enterprises for ten years, during this period he was prominent in the social, literary and civic life of the city. He was always in demand as a public speaker, and upon

one occasion was called upon unexpectedly to address a large crowd of excited citizens upon civic matters; he so splendidly acquitted himself that Henry George pronounced him the ablest extemporaneous speaker he had ever listened to.

He served two years as Colonel of the Second Regiment California National Guards and brought the regiment to a high state of military discipline and efficiency.

During the Kearny-Sand Lot riots Savage was the Chief Military Executive Officer of the Committee of Safety, a Citizens' Vigilance organization that rendered notable and invaluable service in opposing Kearnyism at a time when the Militia could not be depended upon.

During this carnival of unrest and agitation, when demagogues were poisoning the public mind, and when it was a common occurrence for mobs to hoot at, shout down and hurl missiles at any speaker bold enough to oppose the popular side, Col. Savage at a public meeting held in San Francisco, was the only prominent citizen of the Law and Order side that was allowed to speak, and he not only fearlessly exposed the dangerous fallacies that were leading to social and civic anarchy, but was allowed to state the whole case of Law and Order in its entirety. Old residents of San Francisco when recalling those stormy days, have testified that Savage's eloquent, daring and convincing speech was the turning point that marked high-water mark of riot and misrule. He was presented with a handsome testimonial by the citizens of San Francisco for his services in behalf of good government. During these golden years of activity he found time to travel extensively in the United States, Europe and Asia that gave to Savage's well stored mind much new material that was to bear rich fruitage later.

In San Francisco he always enjoyed the friendship and companionship of the literary set that included such men as Henry George, Archibald Gunter, Charles Warren Stoddard and Bret Harte.

As a business man he was noted for his broad grasp of affairs, his stern integrity, his executive ability and for his fairness and liberality to his employes. He retired from active business affairs in 1884 and practiced law for several years in San Francisco with his youngest brother, Lincoln Ewart Savage, but was restless and eager to again wing his flight into the larger world.

In 1890 legal affairs called him to New York and from that time until his death he lived either in New York or in Europe, and devoted himself to literary work. There had been no indication that the daring soldier and world-wide traveler was to develop into one of the brilliant writers of the day. This came about in the most common place way. In the fall of 1890 Savage returned from a perilous trip to Honduras where he had been attacked by jungle fever and nearly died from exposure. Arriving in New York, a classmate, David Stewart Denison, carried him off to his country home at Lake George to build up. While slowly convalescing, Denison, recalling the old days at the "Point" when Dick Savage's brilliant and witty skits were the life of the Corps, suggested to him that he kill the weary hours of inactivity by writing up his experiences. The result was "My Official Wife." This dashing story was first a mere sketch of five chapters but was received with such marked favor by his friends to whom he read it, that he was inspired to re-write and extend it to a novel. The story is said to be literally true up to the arrival at St. Petersburg. Savage had left Madam Savage at Saint Heliers, Isle of Jersey for a run to St. Petersburg where they had friends. It was in the fall of 1884, just after the killing of the Czar and the police were in an ugly mood. The heroine of the story was a daring conspirator, she was captured later at Wilna, Russia, and Col. Savage believed she was quietly strangled and buried, as she was never heard of again. The story won for him a great and instantaneous success, and was soon translated into every modern language, and had the distinction of

falling under the ban in Russia where its sale and publication was prohibited. The play founded upon this story is still popular in England, Germany and France. This success led Savage to devote his entire time to original literary work, he wrote in all about thirty novels, nearly all are based upon some personal experience of the author or of his friends from whom he heard the story at first hands. Many readers and a steady sale tell the story of their brilliancy and fascination for lovers of real flesh and blood romance.

Full of life and action, "My Official Wife," "Prince Schamyl's Wooing" and the "Little Lady of Lagunitas" may be classed as the best. The first made his fame, the second has been classed with "Charles O'Malley" as a novel of military life. In this book there is a description of a cavalry charge that can not be surpassed. The third has been pronounced by many as the best novel of California days of that period extant.

Savage was not egotistic as to his own literary work, indeed once when reproached by an intimate and life long friend for not writing for fame, he replied that he merely wrote such books as the average public wanted, and truly the vogue of his works is his justification. He, however, expressed the opinion that if he ever could have two years of time all to himself, he might write a book that would be satisfactory to himself.

In his earlier years when he first visited Europe, he enjoyed the intimate friendship of Thomas Buchanan Read, the gifted American poet and painter with whom he roamed over Europe, and at whose death bed he attended as an intimate friend; to this intimacy is largely due the abandonment of business for literature as his life work. Upon the out-break of the Spanish-American war, although almost an invalid, Savage promptly tendered his services to the Government that had educated him, and was commissioned Major of the Second U. S. Vol. Engineers, May 31, 1898; he served with his regiment

at Montauk Point, L. I., Savannah, Ga., and Havana, Cuba, being present on January 1, 1899, in command of his battalion at the final surrender of Havana.

In April, 1899, he was mustered out with his regiment, broken in health from the yellow fever contracted in Cuba, but he at once demanded that he be given service in the Philippines, and despite the urgent remonstrances of his closest friends, and his broken health, he was commissioned as senior Captain 27th U. S. Vol. Infantry, and went into camp with his company and worked incessantly to make a model company in drill and discipline. He accomplished all this but at the expense of his small remnant of strength, and was forced to apply for an honorable discharge on account of ill health, and most sorrowfully saw his regiment depart for the Philippines without him.

Any critical estimate and summary of Savage's mind and character is not easy; he was essentially many-sided, full of moods, quaint conceits and vagaries, and of "an infinite fancy" that made him a most delightful companion and an incomparable raconteur. He possessed a faculty almost instantaneous in its rapidity in sizing up and grasping all the salient features of a situation whether of business, politics or of public affairs, and then could eloquently state the situation in clearest terms that charmed and convinced.

Big-hearted, eloquent, impulsive, easily moved by distress or suffering, sympathetic to a degree rare in an Anglo-Saxon, the man that those that knew him best, and by that knowledge loved him, has gone from us, and the place he filled must be unfilled for evermore, for none can take his place. The most generous heart that mortal man could carry, he seemed to make every one's troubles and griefs his own, and by his tender sympathy and kindly acts, he has caused many a man to take fresh heart, and live more worthily. He had an extremely high strung, nervous temperament and was full of intensive energy that was contagious, always a masterful man, he was

easily moved by an appeal to his heart or sympathies. His life was always stormy and restless, and he may have accomplished in this world less than might have been expected from his brilliant endowment, but he left aching hearts when he died, and could Fame have done more for him?

Savage was a loyal son of his Alma Mater, the good name and fame of the Academy were always dear to him, and to the training he received at the "Point" he always attributed whatever of success he achieved in life. Years ago when the writer of this imperfect sketch was in the Soudan and Savage in Russia, in a letter that came to him in the desert, Savage spoke of his affection for the Academy, and added these lines that were afterwards extended in his published book of short poems:

"Dear Alma Mater, reverently,
On thy Fame-lighted brow,
I lovingly my tribute leave,
And breathe a blessing low;
May Glory gild thy honored age,
Thy sons ever worthy be,
To guard thy name with jealous care,
And dying, honor thee."

His death was the result of an accident; while crossing Sixth avenue, near Forty-second street, New York, he was run down by a passing wagon. He was taken to the Roosevelt Hospital and lingered from October 3d to the night of the 11th. He was buried at West Point; and so the end came, and the eager, restless spirit sleeps amid the scenes he loved so well in his bright youth.

One of his minor poems seems a fitting tribute to his memory:

"Youth laid its glowing hand upon my brow,
The fire it lent is chilled and sinking now.
Hope smiled and flattered to the very last,
Then from my side, unseen, went smiling past.
The record all summed; howe'er the story ran,
Of joys that thrilled or hopes that failed,
There lived a man."

E. O. F.
Class "68."